

THE COMPLETE ROUTINE + PRACTICE APP

ULTIMATE ALTERNATE PICKING WORKOUT

A SYSTEMATIC ALTERNATE-PICKING WORKOUT DESIGNED TO PREPARE
YOUR HANDS FOR THE MUSIC YOU ACTUALLY WANT TO PLAY.

JON BJORK | MUSIC

PRACTICE

PROGRESS

WALKTHROUGH

POSITION

1

5

9

13

17

START ON

DOWNSTROKE

UPSTROKE

FINGERINGS

☒ TWO-FINGER / 6

☒ THREE-FINGER / 4

☒ FOUR-FINGER / 1

The tab is written at the first position. Play it with your index finger on fret 1.

This pass takes 3:16 per position at 50 BPM.

START THE ROUTINE

50

BPM

RELAXED

ACCURATE

TONE

Stop at the first sign of tension.

Never faster than perfect.

Practice the sound you want.

JON BJORK MUSIC

LEVEL UP YOUR PLAYING

HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

Read This First.

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This is my alternate picking routine and warm up. I did not start doing this on day one, but I have done similar things for years, and I feel it has benefitted my picking technique so much that it is worth talking about.

At 60 BPM the whole routine takes seven minutes and eight seconds per position. Doing it once starting with a downstroke and once with an upstroke is around fifteen minutes, and that is what I usually do.

RUN IT IN THE APP

The app plays the routine for you. Every fingering and every string pattern in order, in time, with the tab on screen. It keeps your place, so your attention can go on how it sounds instead of on what comes next. It also logs which positions and which starting strokes you have actually done.

It is made for a desktop. Trying to do this on a phone would be quite annoying.

BEFORE YOU START

Start at 50 BPM. The metronome is set to eighth notes, so 50 BPM is 100 notes a minute. I usually do this myself at around 60 to 80.

Sometimes I use a metronome, sometimes I just count. That is up to you. What you want is an even tempo, at a speed you can actually play cleanly.

PART 1

Why It Is Worth Doing Properly.

Some people swear by learning licks instead, or pieces, or working on scale exercises you can actually use in music. Those are all valid approaches and I do them as well. But for quickly going through the most common movements that will appear in all those licks and scale exercises, a systematic approach is best, at least for me.

These Exercises Sound Like Crap

That might feel like a bad thing. I think it is a good thing.

Say you are trying to learn an Eric Johnson or a John Petrucci lick. You have heard it up to speed so many times that you sort of unconsciously push yourself to get to that speed, because you can hear how it is supposed to sound. And if you could play it up to speed as it should be, you would not need to practise it in the first place.

These exercises will sound bad regardless of the tempo you play them at, in terms of the melody, but that frees you up to focus on how your technique actually sounds. You will not have that urge to speed it up, because you will not really make it that much better. That is the idea here.

What I Am Actually Going For

I just want to be able to play it at a slow, even tempo, with technique and tone as close to perfect as I can get. That changes every day, and you always try to get a bit better in that department. It is not about speed. It is about evenness and not tensing up.

RAT · RELAXED, ACCURATE, TONE

Whatever I am practising on the guitar, I always have a pretty corny acronym in mind.

Relaxed. Do I feel tension anywhere? I stop, shake it out and try again. You should not feel tense when you are playing. Live, in the middle of a song, you have to push through. In practice you never do.

Accurate. That one sort of speaks for itself. Definitely no flams, where the fingers are not connecting properly.

Tone. Whatever you find is the best tone for you.

PART 1 · CONTINUED

Tone, Sound And Tension.

Tone Is Part Of It

You see a lot of people really digging in when they practise technique, thinking that will somehow translate into perfectly executed awesome tone when they play for real. In my experience it does not work that way. You are programming your brain, and your brain controls what you do. Sit around practising super hard and you will probably play super hard, with pretty bad tone, if you can even play fast at all when you play that hard.

So whatever you feel is a good tone, strive for that, even when you are practising something as unmusical as this.

What I Play It On

I like doing this on my acoustic. You really have to be on the ball, keeping the dynamics even and all that stuff.

On the electric I go for my regular distorted tone with the volume rolled down to about a quarter, so I get a semi distorted sound. It is very dynamic, so I cannot really hide behind the distortion. And compared to a clean sound, if I get another string ringing I hear it much more easily.

That is my preference. Do whatever works for you.

You Should Not Get Tired

If you feel tense at all you need to stop and reset. Maybe start at a lower tempo, because if you are tensing up then something is up. You should not get tired doing this.

It is also really hard to do while watching Netflix. It is not a mindless exercise.

THE ONE RULE

Never faster than you can play it perfectly and completely relaxed.

PART 2

The Eleven Fingerings.

Divide the fretting fingers up by number, one two three four. Start with the two finger combinations, then the three finger ones, then the one with all four.

TWO FINGERS · 6

1-2
1-3
1-4
2-3
2-4
3-4

THREE FINGERS · 4

1-2-3
1-2-4
1-3-4
2-3-4

FOUR FINGERS · 1

1-2-3-4

These are finger groups, not permutations. I am not talking about every permutation within a fingering, just about using the group.

How To Remember The Order

The easiest way to remember these, and I never need a list beside me to see them all, is to think of the lowest number first. The lowest possible pair is 1-2. Then 1-3, then 1-4, then 2-3, 2-4, 3-4. Pretty easy.

The three finger groups work the same way: 1-2-3, 1-2-4, 1-3-4, 2-3-4. And finally 1-2-3-4.

Really you could do whatever you want here. Thinking about it like that makes it much easier for me to know where I am, so I do not skip any.

THE AWKWARD ONE

2-3-4 is pretty challenging for most people, so it is a good one to work on.

PART 3

Three Ways Through The Strings.

Every fingering goes through three different modes, the ones that pop up when you actually play: arpeggiated, adjacent strings, then string skipping. You do all three for one fingering before moving on to the next one.

The tab shows the 1-2 fingering. Everything is written at the first fret because that also shows you the fingerings, so you can read the fret numbers as finger numbers and move the shape all over the place.

1 · Arpeggiated

One note per string. You play the fingering repeatedly, but you change string every time. One on the low E, two on the A, one on the D, two on the G, one on the B, two on the top E. Then back down.

1-2 · ARPEGGIATED10 NOTES

UP

□ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽

e ————— 2 —

B ————— 1 —

G ————— 2 —

D ————— 1 —

A ————— 2 —

E — 1 —

AND BACK

□ ▽ □ ▽

e —————

B — 1 —

G — 2 —

D — 1 —

A — 2 —

E —

It turns around at the top. I do not double up anything, I just go straight back.

PART 3 · CONTINUED

Adjacent Strings.

2 · Adjacent Strings

Scalar. You treat it like a scale, and with these finger patterns it becomes like a weird pentatonic thing. That is the closest thing you can relate it to. With three fingers it is like a weird three note per string scale.

It turns around at the top, so you do not hit the top note twice. You go straight back down.

1-2 · ADJACENT STRINGS

22 NOTES

UP

AND BACK

Twenty two notes on the two finger version. With three fingers it is thirty four, and with all four it is forty six.

PART 3 · CONTINUED

String Skipping.

3 · String Skipping

Every other string. Low E, then D, then back to the A, then G, then D, then B, then G, then the top E. Then it turns around at the top the same way.

You could do a lot of variations here. I stick to a regular one string skip.

1-2 · STRING SKIPPING

30 NOTES

UP

□ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □

e ————— 1 —
 B ————— 1 - 2 —
 G ————— 1 - 2 ————— 1 - 2 —
 D ————— 1 - 2 ————— 1 - 2 —
 A ————— 1 - 2 —
 E — 1 - 2 —

AND BACK

▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽ □ ▽

e — 2 - 1 —
 B ————— 2 - 1 —
 G ————— 2 - 1 ————— 2 - 1 —
 D ————— 2 - 1 ————— 2 - 1 —
 A ————— 2 - 1 —
 E ————— 2 —

THE FOUR FINGER EXCEPTION

Since we are using a six string, I cannot cover four strings the same way on the arpeggiated version. So I go up four strings, restart on the D string, and go back the same way. That is the only difference.

PART 4

One Unbroken Pass.

Each exercise stops one note short of the note it started on, because that note is where the next one begins. Play them in order and the whole thing is one long line. We never double pick anything, just to be clear.

What I try to do, and what I would recommend, is to go from one straight into the next without stopping. Arpeggiated, adjacent, skipping, then straight into the next fingering. It takes more focus, and it actually takes less time.

The Picking Runs Straight Through

I am alternate picking throughout, and it does not restart at each exercise. Because the exercises are different lengths, the stroke you land on changes as you move through them.

You can get a clue from that. If you started the entire exercise on a downstroke, the last note before you shift to the next one tells you where you are.

Coming Out Of One Group Into The Next

When I come back from the string skips on 1-4, the next combination is 2-3, so I do not go back to the index finger. All the other combinations start on either the second or the third finger, so once you know where you end it is not that hard to do.

The ideal is to go through the entire thing, the two finger combinations, the three finger combinations and the four finger one, without stopping. But if you feel tense at all you need to stop and reset.

PART 5

Positions, And Turning The Picking Around.

Everything is written at the first position because that also shows you the fingerings. Then you apply it at the fifth, the ninth, the thirteenth and the seventeenth.

Five positions are plenty. The whole point is to get a feel for all the different tensions across the neck, and the different fret distances. I could go up to the twenty first or the twenty fourth, and I think that is too much. It is really annoying to try to do it up there. But I am not your dad, I cannot stop you.

One Position Down, The Next One Up

Start the first position with a downstroke and the next one with an upstroke. You can toggle this in the app, and it is super important. Everything turns around picking wise and it feels quite different.

Even if you do the full five positions, I would not go through all of them starting with a downstroke and then all of them again starting with an upstroke. I think that is too much.

Let It Cycle

Instead, alternate as you go up the neck. Downstroke in the first, upstroke in the fifth, downstroke in the ninth, upstroke in the thirteenth, downstroke in the seventeenth.

Because there is an odd number of positions, the next time round it turns itself around. The next day you start on an upstroke in the first, a downstroke in the fifth, an upstroke in the ninth, and so on. Two times through and you have covered everything both ways.

THE CYCLE		FIVE POSITIONS				
		FRET 1	FRET 5	FRET 9	FRET 13	FRET 17
FIRST TIME		Down	Up	Down	Up	Down
NEXT TIME		Up	Down	Up	Down	Up

Doing only two positions a day works the same way. Downstroke on the first, upstroke on the fifth. Next day a downstroke on the ninth and an upstroke on the thirteenth. Then a downstroke on the seventeenth and an upstroke back on the first. You cycle through it.

PART 6

The Session.

Start at 50 BPM. I usually do this at around 60 to 80. At 60 one position takes seven minutes and eight seconds, and the app shows you the number for whatever tempo you have picked, so you can work out the rest.

WHAT	HOW LONG AT 60 BPM	WHEN
One position	About 7 minutes	The least worth doing
Two positions, one down one up	About 15 minutes	What I suggest
All five, alternating	About 35 minutes	The full routine

Seven minutes times five positions is thirty five. At 50 BPM add about a fifth to all of those. At 80 take about a quarter off.

What I Suggest

At least two positions. One starting on a downstroke, the next starting on an upstroke, then pick up where you left off the next day and let it cycle.

Doing all five positions is great, and alternating the stroke as you go is the best use of your time. Doing all five twice over, once down and once up in every position, is too much.

DO NOT RUSH IT

The whole point is getting everything perfect. It does not sound great, but it gives you a really good workout covering a lot of the situations that will pop up in actual music, and that is what it is for. To prepare you for actual music.

After a few repetitions of these the gains sort of go down drastically, as would any exercise if you overdo it. Use common sense and it will be awesome.

I really feel this is a great way to start the day, and to make your first contact with the instrument a technical one. You can form really, really good habits by doing this correctly.

KEEP TRACK

Let The App Keep The Score.

Since you are cycling the starting stroke as you move up the neck, what matters is which ones you have actually done rather than which ones you think you have done. That is the part the app is for.

It logs every session: how long you played, at what tempo, in which position and which stroke you started on. The grid fills in as you go.

GROUND COVERED					PROGRESS
	POS 1	POS 5	POS 9	POS 13	POS 17
DOWNSTROKE	✓	—	✓	—	✓
UPSTROKE	—	✓	—	✓	—

There is also a calendar with the time you put in on each day, and a running streak.

YOUR LOG, AND YOUR BACKUPS

If you are already in The Practice Room or Practice Room Pro, this is connected to your Practice Lab, because that is the version you are using, and it counts toward your overall practice log.

If you bought it on the outside you still have your own calendar. Just remember it lives in your browser, so take care of the backups. It is a very small file that you can export and load wherever you want to use it.

THAT IS THE WHOLE THING

I hope you got something out of this, and that it will help you as much as it has helped me.

Any questions, just email me at jon@jonbjorkmusic.com and I will get back to you as soon as I can. Good luck.